

The European act of state in honour of Helmut Kohl was an act of state to honour former German Chancellor Helmut Kohl following his death, and took place at the European Parliament in Strasbourg, France on 1 July 2017 from 11 AM to 1 PM. It was announced by the European Commission on 18 June 2017, and was the first European act of state in the history of the European Union. It was co-organised by the European Commission, the European Parliament and the European Council.

Helmut Kohl died on 16 June 2017 and was survived by his sons Walter Kohl and Peter Kohl, and grandchildren Johannes Volkmann and Leyla Kohl. The European Commission announced that it was planning a grand ceremony, attended by European heads of state and government, to honour Kohl. Kohl was one of only three people to be awarded the title Honorary Citizen of Europe by the European Union, and was, together with French President François Mitterrand, one of the two principal architects of the Maastricht Treaty which established the European Union and the euro currency. He was also considered the "father of the German reunification."

Speakers

The speakers at the ceremony were, in the following order

Antonio Tajani, President of the European Parliament and former European Commissioner for Industry and Entrepreneurship

Jean-Claude Juncker, President of the European Commission and former Prime Minister of Luxembourg

Donald Tusk, President of the European Council and former Prime Minister of Poland

Felipe González, former Prime Minister of Spain

Bill Clinton, former President of the United States and a contemporary friend of Kohl

Dmitry Medvedev, Prime Minister and former President of Russia

Emmanuel Macron, President of France

Angela Merkel, Chancellor of Germany

Other guests

Incumbent heads of state and government

Frank-Walter Steinmeier, President of Germany

Dalia Grybauskaitė, President of Lithuania

Petro Poroshenko, President of Ukraine

Andrzej Duda, President of Poland

Alexander Van der Bellen, President of Austria

Benjamin Netanyahu, Prime Minister of Israel

Viktor Orbán, Prime Minister of Hungary

Mark Rutte, Prime Minister of the Netherlands

Stefan Löfven, Prime Minister of Sweden

Charles Michel, Prime Minister of Belgium

Juha Sipilä, Prime Minister of Finland

Theresa May, Prime Minister of the United Kingdom

Former heads of state and government

Joachim Gauck, former President of Germany

Christian Wulff, former President of Germany

Horst Köhler, former President of Germany

Gerhard Schröder, former Chancellor of Germany

King Juan Carlos and Queen Sofia of Spain

Felipe González, former Prime Minister of Spain

Jose Maria Aznar, former Prime Minister of Spain

Paavo Lipponen, former Prime Minister of Finland

John Major, former Prime Minister of the United Kingdom

Nicolas Sarkozy, former President of France

Romano Prodi, former Prime Minister of Italy and President of the European Commission

Silvio Berlusconi, former Prime Minister of Italy

Mario Monti, former Prime Minister of Italy and European Commissioner for Competition

Guy Verhofstadt, former Prime Minister of Belgium

Jerzy Buzek, former Prime Minister of Poland and President of the European Parliament

Franz Vranitzky, former Chancellor of Austria

Herman Van Rompuy, former Prime Minister of Belgium and President of the European Council

Wolfgang Schäussel, former Chancellor of Austria

Jacques Santer, former Prime Minister of Luxembourg and President of the European Commission

Rudolf Schuster, former President of Slovakia

José Manuel Barroso, former Prime Minister of Portugal and President of the European Commission

Aníbal Cavaco Silva, former President of Portugal

Jean Chrétien, former Prime Minister of Canada

B. J. Habibie, former President of Indonesia

European Union leaders

Martin Schulz, former President of the European Parliament

Hans-Gert Pöttering, former President of the European Parliament

Josep Borrell, former President of the European Parliament

Pat Cox, former President of the European Parliament

Frans Timmermans, First Vice President of the European Commission

Federica Mogherini, High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy

Günther Oettinger, European Commissioner for Budget and Human Resources

Maroš Šefčovič, European Commissioner for Energy Union

Controversy

No member of the Kohl family, Kohl's children and grandchildren, attended the ceremony, owing to a feud with Kohl's controversial second wife Maike Kohl-Richter, who had among other things barred them from paying their respects to their father and grandfather after his death, ignored their wish for a ceremony in Berlin and their wish that Kohl should be interred alongside his parents and his wife of four decades Hannelore Kohl in the family tomb. Richter had also attempted to bar Chancellor Merkel from speaking and wanted to have Viktor Orbán, who has fiercely criticized Merkel's refugee policy, speak instead.

== References ==